The similarities may not be obvious, though. They will become clearer when we review 2022 from a vantage point in future, when history reassesses the long march of 2022—the Bharat Jodo Yatra. In 1942, almost immediately after Gandhi raised his ‘do or die’ slogan, he was arrested and taken to prison with Kasturba and Mahadev Desai, both of whom died in prison. The Indian National Congress and three of its regional committees were banned; a hundred thousand went to jail and nearly as many went underground to continue the agitation. Five years later, India had gained Independence. In the same time interval, the fascist regimes in Italy and Germany also crumbled. By 1947, Mussolini and Hitler, who commanded the world’s most powerful armed forces in 1942, had become names uttered only in contempt. In 1942, colonialism was at the zenith of its exploitative might. By 1947, European colonialism had begun to look like a relic of the medieval Dark Ages.

Not everyone was convinced of Gandhi’s method of resistance even in 1942, even after he had demonstrated what was possible over the previous decades. How can you fight the military might of the colonial power and fascists with non-violence and non-cooperation, his critics would ask. Similar doubts are being expressed today about the Bharat Jodo Yatra. How will this long march combat the strong-arm politics of the adversary? How will it stop the intimidation of citizens through constant surveillance? How will it uproot fear, falsehood and propaganda? As I’d written earlier, the similarities between Gandhi’s Bharat Chhodo agitation and the Bharat Jodo Yatra go far beyond their surface-level attributes. Perhaps the most important feature they share is the realization that the push for freedom must come from the people, which, in turn, must necessarily involve their awakening. Implicit in Rahul’s embrace of the Gandhian method is the conviction that *his* battle against the prevailing economic disparities, the communal divide and the collapse of democratic institutions is also *their* battle. It is a method designed to make people fearless and weaken the hold of the State over the minds of people. It is the method that taught people the strength of self-regulation or swaraj. It worked then, and beyond all expectations. Why won’t it work now?